Section I

READING



Listen to your teacher read this section. Discuss with your partner and answer the questions.

Pan Am Flight 73

It was the morning of September 5, 1986. The aircraft, Pan Am Flight 73 with 360 passengers on board, had just arrived from Mumbai and was ready to depart from Jinnah International Airport in Karachi for its destination — the United States. Unfortunately, the flight was **hijacked** by four heavily armed terrorists while it was parked at Karachi airport.

The passengers on the plane hailed from different countries — there were Indians, Germans, Americans, and Pakistanis, among others. The terrorists were more intent on targeting the Americans. When Neerja was told to collect the passports of the passengers, Neerja managed to hide their passports and discard them down the rubbish chute. With her help at least 39 American passengers were saved out of 41. The hijackers wanted to fly to Israel and crash the plane against a building. On being confronted with this unexpected **calamity**, Neerja immediately sprang into action. She attempted first and foremost, to alert the pilots in the cockpit of the hijacked plane so that they could save themselves. When the terrorists saw that, they **assaulted** her. She then passed on the warning in a code, which alerted the pilots. As per the mandate, they made an escape through the alternate exit so that the terrorists were at a loss of pilots who could be forced to fly the plane to the terrorists' desired location.

"I will die, but not run away"— this is what a young Neerja told her mother when they had discussed the sensitive situation of a hypothetical hijack. Her brother Aneesh Bhanot recalls how one day her mother had picked this topic and told Neerja that she must save herself in case a hijack ever took place on a Pan Am flight — the airlines that Neerja was working for. To this, Neerja had asked her mother to never think this way again, for she was determined to not be a coward in such a situation; and she lived up to her word.

The nightmare on the aircraft continued for long. The **frustration** and helplessness of the terrorists grew every hour and their patience was running out. Seventeen hours into the hijack, the plane ran out of power. The terrorists lost their cool and opened fire on the passengers. Armed with grenades, plastic explosive belts, and pistols, the terrorists

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